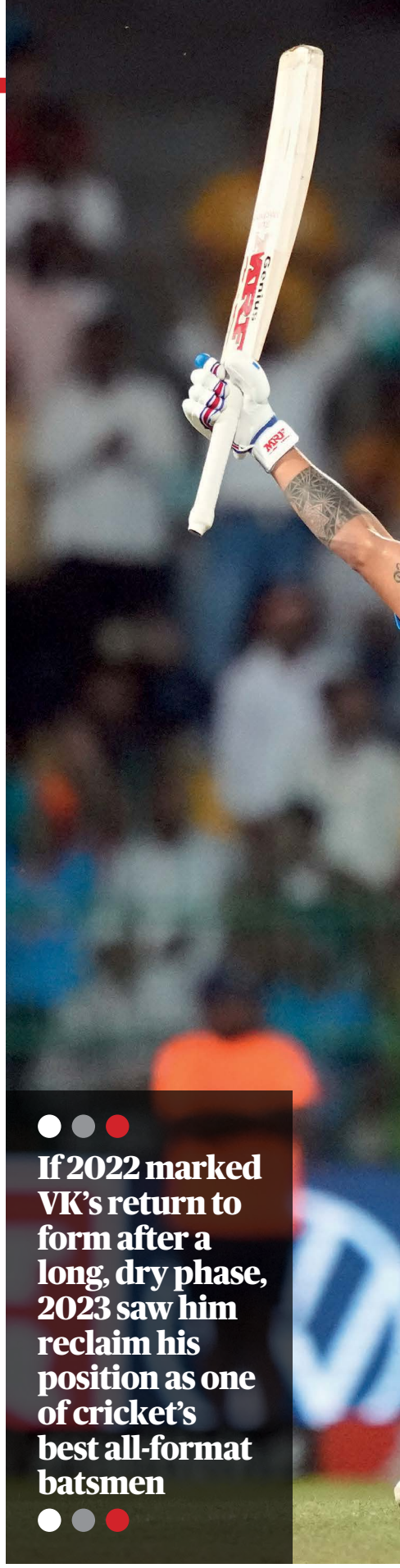
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The Century Man

IN 2023, VIRAT KOHLI RESUMED NORMAL SERVICE AS A GALE FORCE—MONUMENTAL BATTING MILESTONES WERE CROSSED AND THE WORLD WAS DOMINATED AT THE HOME CUP

By Nikhil Naz



If 2022 marked VK's return to form after a long, dry phase, 2023 saw him reclaim his position as one of cricket's best all-format batsmen

VIRAT KOHLI IS AMONG THOSE FEW WHO HAVE surpassed the predictions, nay demands, of greatness thrust upon them early on in their careers, turning in annual exhibitions of excellence over nearly the span of a generation. His 15 years in international cricket—chubby-cheeked wunderkind, then a youth icon with a sharp goatee, neatly prefiguring his present status as the GOAT—define an epoch. Much like Sachin Tendulkar, whose record Kohli broke this year. That he became the first one to score fifty one-day tons in the presence of his childhood idol seemed like divine providence to a man who has kept his tryst with destiny.

That wasn't the only time the protégé surpassed the master this year. Racking up 765 runs in the World Cup at a Bradmanesque 95.62—a shoo-in for Player of the Tournament—Kohli went past Tendulkar's 2003 record for most runs at cricket's big event. Earlier, he also reached 25,000 international runs, in just 549 innings, 28 less than the previous record held by Tendulkar. The year would eventually see him cross the 26,000 mark—again the fastest to do so.

Kohli's career coincides with a period of change in how cricket is played, analysed and consumed. Back in 2008, his debut year, T20—still in its infancy then—barely exacted any influence on the dominant formats. Today, the exigencies of a T20 innings have permeated modern batsmanship, eclipsing more conventional batting styles. Yet, the traditionalist in Kohli swims against